

Lecture 5

The Politics of International Relations Theory:

Critical and Decentring Perspectives

2 March 2026– BAIS

International Relations



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Key Debates and Readings

Questions to be considered:

- How do critical theories challenge the dominant paradigms of international relations, such as realism and liberalism?
- In what ways does postcolonial theory highlight the limitations of traditional IR theories' claims to universality?
- What role does power play in the construction and dissemination of international relations knowledge?

Required readings:

1. Heywood, A., & Whitham, B. (2023). *Global politics* (3rd ed., Chapter 4: Critical theories of global politics). London: Red Globe Press.
2. Seth, S. (2011). Postcolonial theory and the critique of international relations. *Millennium: Journal of International Studies*, 40(1), 167–183.

Contents



Recap



**Critical
Theories**



**Case study Iran
and Ukraine**



Next week

Recap



Realism

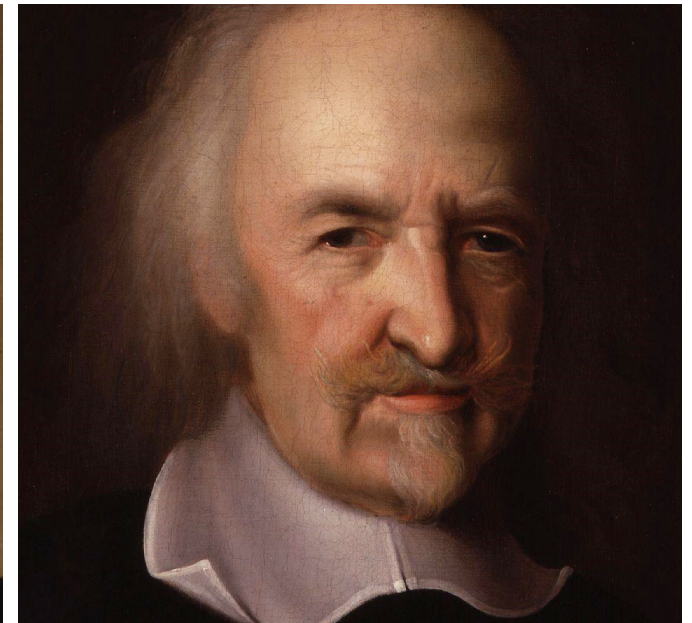
- The state as the central actor in IR (coherent, unitary and rational); they seek power, national interest is key
- Separation of domestic from international politics- only States can play in 'high politics'
- Anarchy and Self Help
- Conflict of Interests
- Power and Security



Thucydides, *The History of the Peloponnesian War* (IV-V century BC)



Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince* (1513)



Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (1651)

Classical and NeoRealism



- **Classic Realism:** ‘a form of realism that explains power politics largely in terms of human selfishness or egoism’ i.e. Morgenthau, 1948 Politics Among Nations
- **Neorealism:** A perspective on international politics that modifies the power politics model by highlighting the structural constraints of the international system; sometimes called ‘new’ or ‘structural’ realism. i.e. Waltz or Mearsheimer
Refrain from normative judgements because they are positivists, and that they analyse a system that pushes states towards policies of survival-> no need for moral
Their claim is that in an anarchical system the ultimate outcome of international politics is war among the major powers. War will one day happen.
- **Defensive realism (Waltz)** Security: ‘states as ‘security maximizers’, placing the desire to avoid attack above a bid for world power’ (Heywood, p. 317)
- **Offensive Realism (Mearsheimer)** Domination- ‘states are ‘power maximizers’, as there is no limit to their desire to control the international environment’ (Heywood, p. 317)

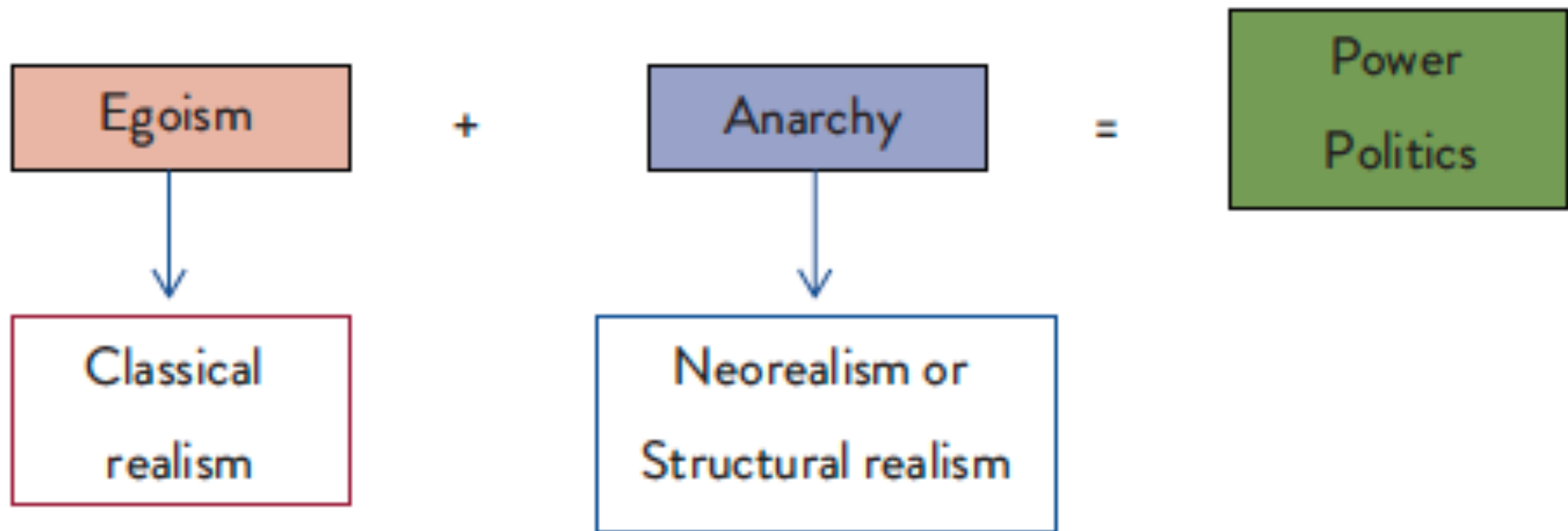
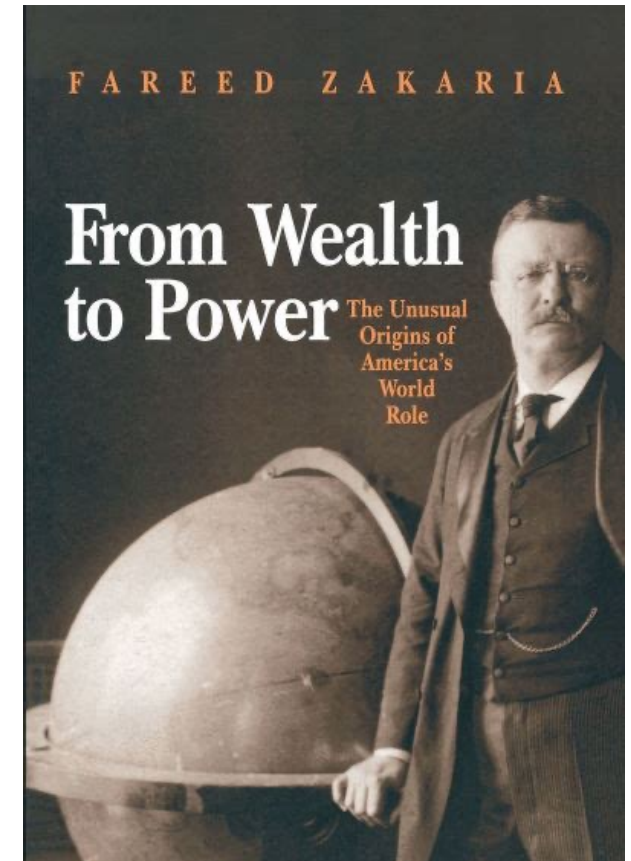


Figure 3.1 Realism's core theme and two main approaches

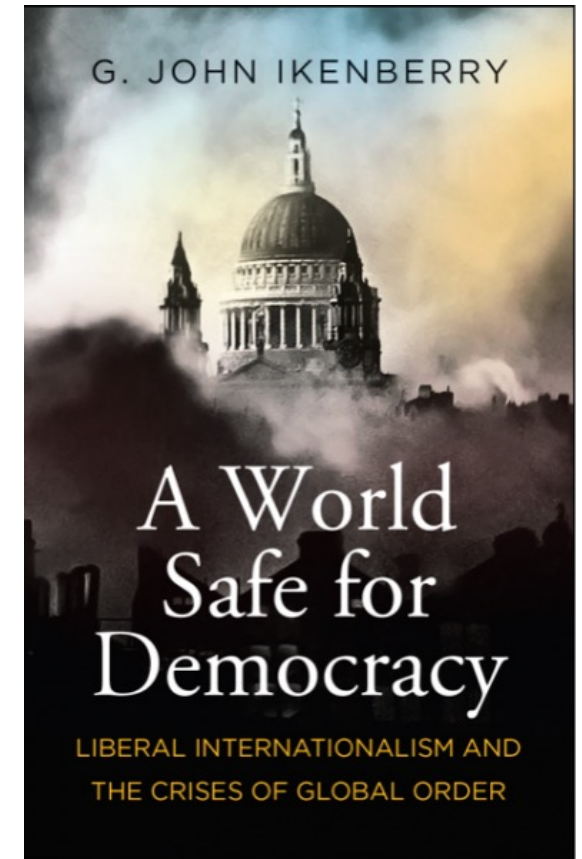
Neoclassical Realism

- State's foreign policy is influenced by both international structures and domestic factors.
- **Rose 1998, Zakaria 1998**
- Under what conditions do capable states either expand or under-expand their “political interests” abroad?
- Compares 1865-1889 as under-expansion and 1889-1908 as expansion linked to domestic factors.
- ‘The development in the United States of what John Brewer calls “the fiscal-military state”—greater powers for the federal government, increased tax revenues, and a strengthened executive—resulted in a foreign policy in the 1890s and 1900s that more accurately reflected, and more directly exploited, America’s growing national power’ (1998, 93)



Liberalism

- ✓ **Preservation of peace, liberty, individual freedom and security**
 - Domestic politics => international politics
 - Liberal/dem. states don't fight each other- **Democratic Peace Theory: Kantian triad** for perpetual peace (I. Kant, 1795 Perpetual Peace)
 - Thus, positive view of the human condition & the power of reason: the condition of international politics (anarchy) is not permanently one of war. Progress is possible.
- ✓ **Collective security**
 - non-state actors matter (international institutions and organizations, multinationals, etc.)
 - Beyond military power: economy, political/legal norms. Importance of 'low politics' and 'soft power'.
 - Complex interdependence



Liberalism	Realism
Optimistic view of human nature.	Pessimistic view of human nature.
State and non-state actors.	State-centric.
Domestic 'regime type' shapes actions.	States as 'black boxes': actions shaped only by power capabilities
Anarchy can be overcome by cooperation leading to 'positive sum games'.	Anarchy determines competition and conflict in 'zero-sum games'.
International institutions as important actors who shape actions and allow for cooperation.	International institutions as vehicles for great power interests.

Constructivism

- Role of ideas, norms and identities
- Constructed interests and views by interaction: Social structures (e.g. economic, legal, political), ideas, norms, culture.
- Challenges the rationalist assumption of which the dominant theories are built (a critique) actions of individuals cannot be understood in isolation of their social environment
- Treating the complexity of social/political systems ; hence, in regionalism national positions are shaped by deeply embedded cultures, ideas, values.
- Norms evolve (e.g. human rights, nuclear taboo)
- Identities matter
- States can learn from past behaviour

Critical Theories



What are Critical Theories in IR?

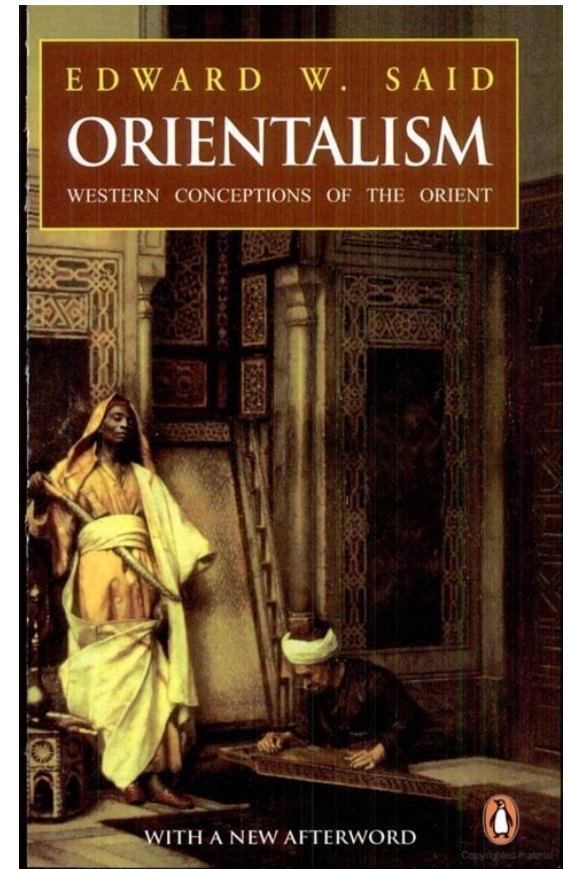
Old tradition in producing knowledge: Plato, Socrates and Aristotle to use the critical method of 'dialectics'
to propose theories around the world politics and then to criticize them

Purpose: to challenge the status quo, the current global order
(for feminist gender is the blind spot, for post-Colonialist legacies and racial hierarchies are not taken into account)
rather than describing the world order

Positionality: Not positivist, they are normative, they reflect interests and expose injustice and enable change. In a way; they are normative
They criticize racism, white supremacy, sexism and patriarchy, capitalism and class exploitation.

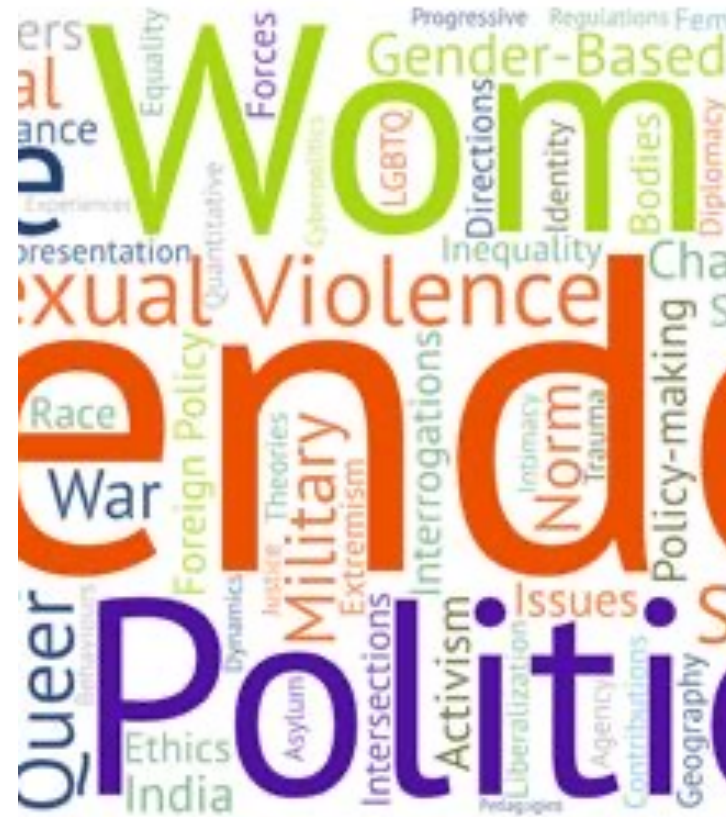
Post-colonialism

- Importance given to inequalities, disparities over power
- Brings studies of race/ethnicity, gender and class in understanding IR
- Highlight Eurocentricism of IR
- IR traditionalist theorist see the world as anarchist, but postcolonialism see it as a hierarchy



Feminist & Gender approaches to IR

- Challenging the absence of women from decision-making in IR and criticizing the IR traditional theories overlooking the impact on women's everyday lives
- Interested in the role of women and men in global politics
- Gender as a **socially constructed identity**
Masculinity/ Femininity based on constructed assumptions
- **IR is 'gender-blind'**; even IR theory so keen on Bourdieu has ignored his feminist critique
- **Different strands of Feminist theories** (liberal feminists, Marxists feminists, post-modern feminism)
- **Intersectionality**



Most influential IR scholars according to US scholars

Rank	Name	N	Percentage in top 4
1	Alexander Wendt	349	30.11
2	Robert O. Keohane	310	26.75
3	John Mearsheimer	257	22.17
4	James Fearon	233	20.1
5	Kenneth Waltz	182	15.7
6	Martha Finnemore	160	13.81
7	Joseph S. Nye Jr.	158	13.63
8	Robert Jervis	119	10.27
9	Stephen M. Walt	103	8.89
10	Kathryn A. Sikkink	92	7.94

[Noda, O. \(2020\). Epistemic hegemony: the Western straitjacket and post-colonial scars in academic publishing. *Revista Brasileira de Política Internacional*, 63.](#)

Why are women thinkers absent from IR's canon? (Hutchings & Owens)



- ‘Across all 22 works, there are 572 cumulative references to all historical figures. Of these, there are nine references to women: 1.57%. This translates to six historical women with some recognition as significant thinkers: Susan Strange, Hannah Arendt, Simone de Beauvoir, Margaret Mead, Susan Sontag, and Virginia Woolf’.
- ‘In our view, *reconstituting* the IR canon is about an ongoing process of unsettling, where the criteria for inclusion and exclusion are constantly in question. In this process, the *recovery* of women’s ideas is important not to inaugurate women from the past as a new set of “greats” addressing perennial questions, but to recognize their central place in the history of international thought and in providing resources for thinking about IR in the present.’



Feminist theories: different school of thought

➤ Liberal feminism (John Stuart Mills)

- Institutional inequalities between men and women based on legal and other obstacles

➤ Marxist feminism (Margaret Benston)

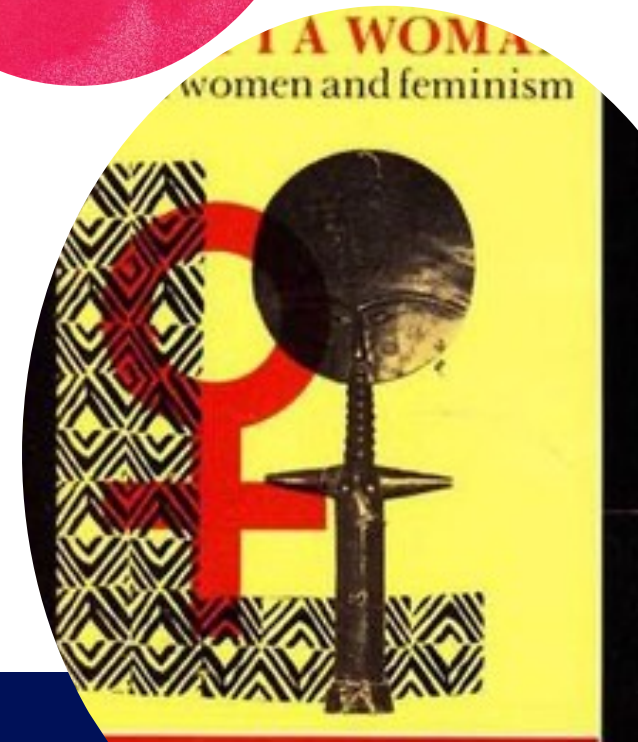
- Inequalities in capitalist forms of production that serve patriarchy and need to be overturned

➤ Post-colonial feminism (Bell hooks)

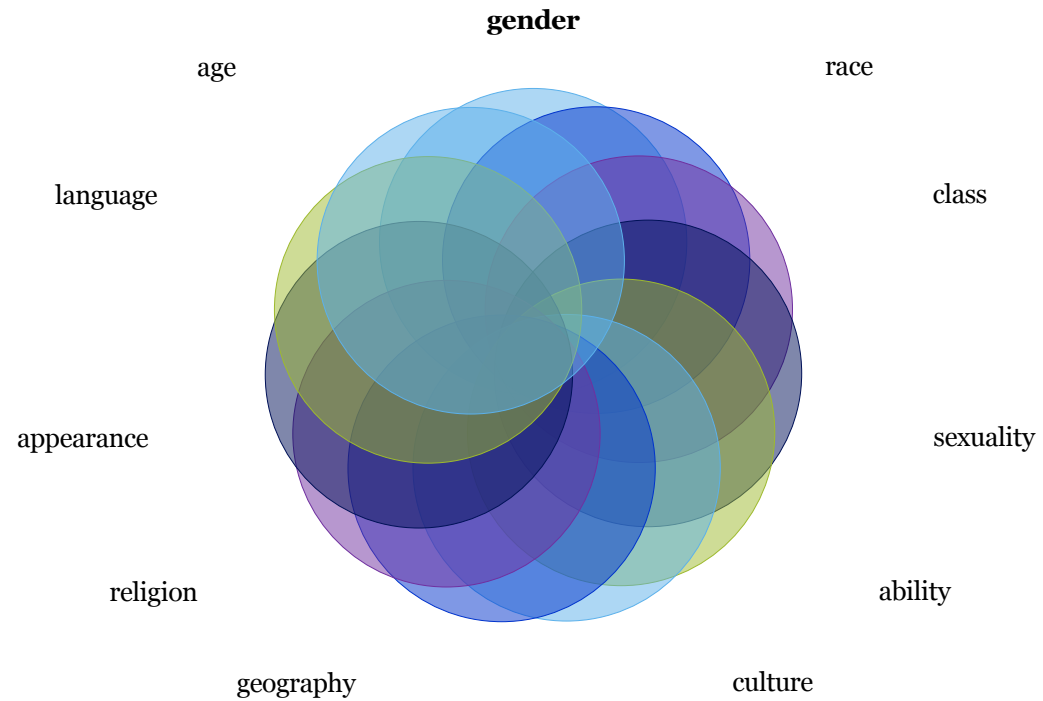
- Inequalities between Western and non-Western women, and need to consider the cultural, racial, ethnical context (*Aint't I a Woman?*, bell hooks, 1981)

➤ Eco-Feminism

- Pays attention to relationship to ecology. Françoise d'Eaubonne, *Le Féminisme ou la Mort* (1974)



Intersectionality



Crenshaw 1991 critical legal race scholar but also European scholars 1983

Marxism and Neo-Marxism

- The world order is driven by powerful **socio-economic forces**, **Global capitalism is the main structure**
- IR reflects **the mode of capitalist production and the power of the capitalist class.**
- Core-Periphery inequalities

Gramsci and the Frankfurt School

- a less economic and more 'humanistic' approach to the critique of capitalism, exploring the significance of its more social and cultural dimensions – such as the alienation of workers from both the means of production and the things they produce.
- **Power:** is not only about coercion but it operates through consent and ideological influence. It cannot be reduced to economic and military might.
- **Hegemony** refers to ideological and cultural leadership maintained. Through institutions, civil society and the state rather than purely coercion
- **The subalterns** are excluded from hegemonic structures and dominant class discourse



Post-structuralism & Discourse: Power in Knowledge

✓ Biopolitics Foucault

- ✓ Foucault argued that French society had reconfigured punishment through the new “humane” practices of “discipline” and “surveillance”, used in new institutions such as prisons, the mental asylums, schools, workhouses and factories.

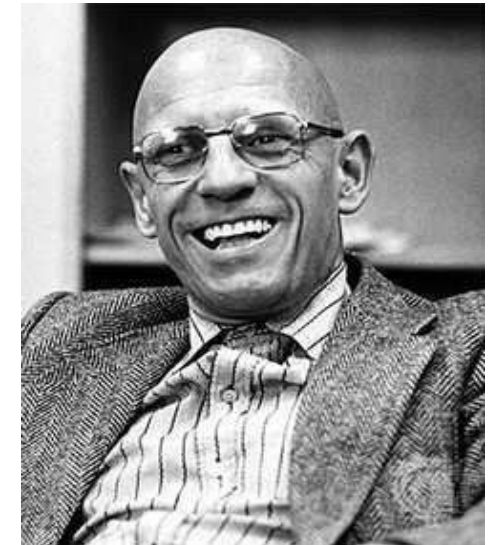
Mouffe and Laclau: Understands discourse and knowledge as power

Articulation – (hegemony): ‘we will call *articulation* any practice establishing a relation among elements such that their identity is modified as a result of the articulatory practice. The structured totality resulting from the articulatory practice, we will call *discourse*.’ (*Hegemony and Socialist Strategy*, p. 105)

Hegemony/articulation

Elements/moments

Discourse



Is the future post-modern/ post-human/ultrasocial?

- What is post-modernism?
- What is post-humanism?
- To what extent do you agree with the argument that IR is likely to be determined by more 'ultrasociality'? (M. Cross, 2024)?



Summary Critical vs. Mainstream



Key criticisms of Mainstream theories

Dimension	Mainstream IR Approaches	Critical IR Approaches
Epistemology	Positivist: assume theories can be objective, neutral, and value-free; seek causal explanation and generalizable laws.	Post-positivist: knowledge is situated and shaped by context, power, and identity; emphasize reflexivity and uncovering bias.
Purpose of Theory	Problem-solving: explain and predict state behaviour; provide tools for policymakers within the existing system.	Emancipatory and transformative: question and seek to change the global order; foreground global justice and alternative futures.
View of Power	Primarily material (military, economic capabilities); sometimes includes soft power; power as the ability to get others to do things.	Multi-dimensional: includes structural power (shaping the system), ideological power (dominant ideas), and discursive power (defining truth and legitimacy).
Actors Considered	State-centric; non-state actors and transnational forces often marginal or secondary.	Broad actor spectrum: includes non-state actors, transnational movements, marginalized groups, and social forces.
Geographical/Intellectual Focus	Western-centric; often treats Western experiences as universal and overlooks how this shapes theory.	Critiques Western centrism; highlights colonial histories, Global South perspectives, and situated knowledge.
Normative Orientation	Prioritizes order and stability in the international system over questions of justice.	Prioritizes global justice, inequality, and emancipation alongside (or over) order.
Relation to the Status Quo	Works within and implicitly reproduces existing global structures.	Questions and challenges existing hierarchies and power relations.
Understanding of Knowledge Production	Knowledge seen as separate from politics; observer can be detached.	Knowledge and power are intertwined; scholars are part of the structures they study.

The 'Decentri ng Turn' in EU Foreign Policy





Principles of decentring

=> How can the EU remain a relevant actor in a multiplex world, under intense contestation/resistance? What tools do we have available? (Wolff and al, 2022)

- Decentring (Fisher Onar and Nicolaidis, 2013)
 - Provincialisation
 - Engagement
 - Reconstruction
- Most challenging is to focus **on reconstruction** defined as 'a renewal of EU external action based on humility, empowerment and mutuality' (Fisher Onar and Nicolaidis, 2013)

Iran



Situation in Iran – Epic Fury

- **Postcolonialism:** the situation would be framed from the legacy of imperialism in the region. 1953 coup against Mossadegh under influence of US and UK; Shah's authoritarianism backed by the West, 1979 revolution as anti-imperial and authoritarian. US-Israeli strike and regime change- imperial move.
- **Feminist IR:** women's bodies is regulated by the state to produce political order, would highlight the role of women in getting the government down i.e. September 2022 and the slogan Woman, Life Freedom after the death of Jina Mahsa Amini, emphasizing their role as political actors; highlighting ethnicity (Kurdish women) or working-class women at the centre of protests; analyse the gendered impact of sanctions.
- **Marxist IR:** looking at class struggles domestically, energy and oil politics as a way for Trump to get oil, economic interests of the US, the West, other countries in the region, but also link revolutionary guards and oil companies
- **Post-structuralist view:** what is the dominant narrative on Epic Furror, how discourse shapes perceptions, how it is meant for a domestic US/ global audience



War in Ukraine

- **Postcolonialism:**

Russia treating Ukraine as a colony, and then Russia is extracting mineral and raw; colonizing Ukraine again. Reunification Slavic countries as under Russian empire.

- **Feminist IR:** 1) masculine armies this create destabilization economically, socially; violences trauma
2) Ukrainian occupied territories- a lot of patriarchy/ less rights
3) Vulnerabilities sanitation, health, access to safety
- **Marxist IR:** resources explain the invasion (gas, oil, grains); US agreement 50% natural minerals to be given up by Ukraine. Core-periphery dynamics. Refusal signing customs union with Russia.
- **Post-structuralist view:** European elites –war against Europe, labels on Russia's war on Ukraine and not Ukraine-Russia war!



Week 6, March 09 – Global Migration: Mobility and Security

Questions to be considered:

What drives international migration nowadays? Who counts as a migrant?
What dilemmas are liberal states facing when it comes to migration?
Why was the global refugee regime set up and what are its deficiencies?

Required readings:

Huysmans, J. “The European Union and the Securitization of Migration”,
Journal of Common Market Studies 38, no. 5 (2000): 751-777.

Hollifield, J. F. (2004). The Emerging Migration State. *The International Migration Review*, 38(3), 885–912. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1747-7379.2004.tb00223.x>

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